invited for a cup of tea and a smoke in the drawing room.[55] *(Three years later, during their occupation of the Persian capital, the Cossack Division would surround the British legation to prevent a repeat of this).*[56]

By the 1907 convention, however, Britain's esteemed position among the Persian people was quickly lost. Despite the best efforts of the British minister, Sir Cecil Spring-Rice, popular opinion believed that Britain had betrayed the Persian revolutionary cause by allying with Russia.[57] Indeed, Persian protest at the convention was almost exclusively aimed at Britain, with Russia seldom mentioned. In the words of one historian, after 1907 'Britain fell from grace; but Russia for many years had been accorded no grace'.[58] That the Persian public had no idea of the existence of the 1907 convention until its announcement was particularly insulting, and only helped fuel the rumours and misinformation that tarred the agreement further (yet another lesson that Curzon would fail to learn twelve years later).[59] The idea that Britain had betrayed Persia in order to share the spoils with Russia was hard to counter, particularly when events such as the Shuster Crisis only appeared to corroborate it. In 1911, the American financial adviser retained by the Persian government, W.M. Shuster, was forced out of office on Russia's protest. Grey had been unwilling to risk a breach in Anglo-Russian relations by defending Shuster and his reforms of Persia's finance.[60] The duplicitous nature of Britain, apparently revealed by the 1907 agreement, would have important repercussions in the years to come. The distrust engendered during this period would permeate Persian society, so that by 1919, when Curzon would try to initiate his own agreement with Tehran, he would receive a very frosty reception.

The Great Game Mentality

Despite appearances then, the Anglo-Russian Convention of 1907 did not mark the end of the Great Game. For, while the agreement might have restrained some of the more overt rivalry once displayed between the two countries, ultimately it could not significantly change the feelings and opinions of many Russians and Britons. In effect, it did not alter the official mind set. It has already been noted in the Introduction how important